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Statistical Models for Tropical Cyclone Prediction in the North Atlantic Ocean through Geographic Sub-Basin Identification

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Abstract Text:

The number and character of North Atlantic Ocean tropical cyclones (TCs) vary significantly each year, driven in part by the relative favorability of large-scale environmental conditions. However, because of a limited historical record, the strength of this response across geographic regions within the Atlantic basin is not well understood. Here we develop geographic sub-basins within the North Atlantic by performing a cluster analysis for key TC genesis factors such as sea surface temperature (SST), genesis potential index (GPI), and vertical wind shear and manually adjusting boundaries to capture gradients in TC origin location and density. For each sub-basin, a regression model is developed in order to evaluate the importance of variables that contribute to TC genesis and sustainability in comparison to other sub-basins. These models estimate frequency, lifespan, and intensity of TCs in a specific sub-basin, as well as evaluate their response to key oceanic modes of variability. Statistical testing is performed to determine the significance of each predictor within a sub-basin and the distinctiveness across sub-basins. From this set of statistical models, we can evaluate how commonly used thresholds for TC development (SST, GPI, shear) vary in magnitude and importance across sub-basins. Overall, this approach allows us to better organize and categorize tropical cyclones and better tease apart the factors that drive their emergence and evolution in this region.

Session Selection:

A119. Tropical Cyclones: Observations, Modeling and Predictability - Today and into the Future

Submitter's E-mail Address:

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Abstract Title:

Statistical Models for Tropical Cyclone Prediction in the North Atlantic Ocean through Geographic Sub-Basin Identification

Requested Presentation Type:

Assigned by Program Committee (oral, poster, or GeoBurst)

Recording Permission Given?

Yes

Previously Published?:

No

Abstract Payment:

Paid (agu-2091346-7000-5679-1040-2750)

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